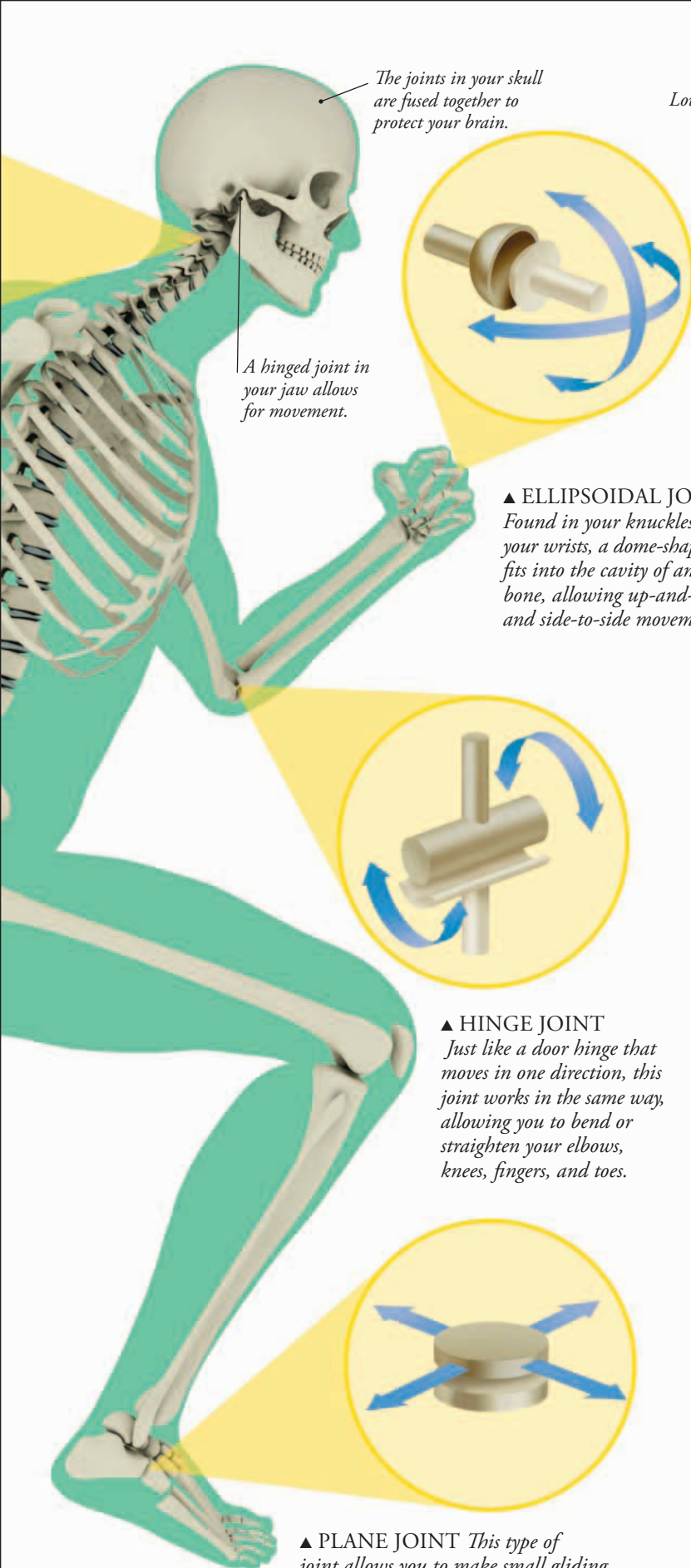




The joints in your skull are fused together to protect your brain.

A hinged joint in your jaw allows for movement.

▲ ELLIPSOIDAL JOINT

Found in your knuckles and in your wrists, a dome-shaped bone fits into the cavity of another bone, allowing up-and-down and side-to-side movements.

▲ HINGE JOINT

Just like a door hinge that moves in one direction, this joint works in the same way, allowing you to bend or straighten your elbows, knees, fingers, and toes.

▲ PLANE JOINT This type of joint allows you to make small gliding movements only. It forms where two flat bone ends fit tightly together, such as in your ankle.

Lower leg bone

Heel bone

Sole bone

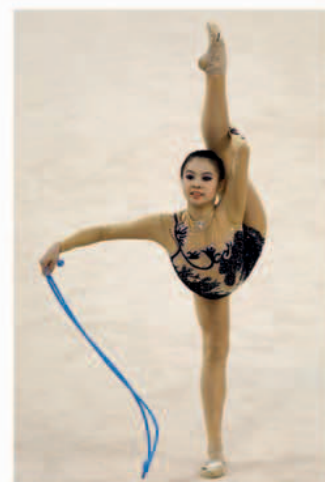
STRONG HOLD

Many joints, such as these between the foot and leg bones, are held together by tough straps of fibrous tissue called ligaments. These allow the joints to move but prevent the bones from being pulled apart.

More than a dozen ligaments are attached to your ankle, heel, and sole bones, providing both support and stability.

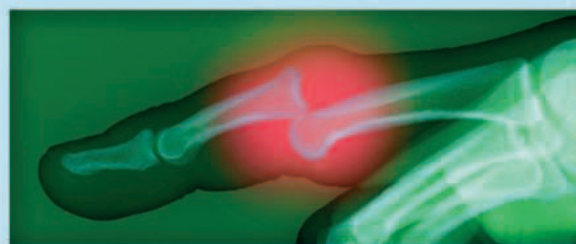
SUPER FLEXIBLE

People whose bodies are very flexible are sometimes called double-jointed. This doesn't mean that they have more joints than normal; rather, their ligaments are more stretchy, making their joints more flexible. Gymnasts in particular have unusually flexible joints, but they also need to maintain this flexibility by exercising.



LOOK CLOSER: PULLED APART

Sometimes a sudden knock or blow can force bones out of their normal position. The joint between those bones is said to be dislocated. Doctors treat a dislocation by forcefully moving bones back into their correct position.



▲ DISLOCATED FINGER This X-ray of the hand shows clearly how two finger bones have been pulled apart at a knuckle joint.